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Source: *American Anthropologist*, New Series, Vol. 65, No. 6 (Dec., 1963), pp. 1314-1327

Published by: Wiley on behalf of the American Anthropological Association

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/668454>

Accessed: 05-08-2026 03:53 UTC

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Utani: Joking, Sexual License and Social Obligations Among the Luguru¹

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A “JOKING RELATIONSHIP” has been defined as “a relation between two persons in which one is by custom permitted, and in some instances required, to tease or make fun of the other, who in turn is required to take no offence” (Radcliffe-Brown 1940:195). While the ethnographic literature frequently makes mention of joking, sexual license, or obligations between specified members of a society, among the Luguru of Tanganyika all three of these behavior patterns are to be found in a relationship, known as *utani*, between entire clans.

The most common pattern noted in the literature² is to permit joking within the same generation, sometimes with alternate generations and only rarely between contiguous generations. The Luguru case is somewhat atypical in that permitted disrespect may occur between all members of so-called *watani* clans, irrespective of generation or sex. Also, the relationship is symmetrical, in that the person being teased may retaliate.

Radcliffe-Brown regards the joking relationship as a technique of resolving problems inherent in the social structure and an alternative to extreme respect or avoidance. He cites the change in interpersonal relations that accompanies marriage as an example of such a problem, as it involves both attachment and separation for the parties concerned, or what he terms “social conjunction” and “social disjunction”:

The man has his own definite position in the social structure, determined for him by his birth into a certain family, lineage or clan. The great body of his rights and duties and the interests and activities that he shares with others are the result of his position. Before the marriage his wife's family are outsiders for him as he is an outsider for them. This constitutes a social disjunction which is not destroyed by the marriage. The social conjunction results from the continuance, though in altered form, of the wife's relation to her family, their continued interest in her and in her children (1940:196-7).

Social disjunction thus refers to divergence of interests and the possibility of conflict and hostility, while conjunction requires that friction be avoided or minimized. Radcliff-Brown's hypothesis is that “both the joking relationship which constitutes an alliance between clans or tribes, and that between relatives by marriage, are modes of organizing a definite and stable system of social behavior in which conjunctive and disjunctive components . . . are maintained and combined” (1940:200). The value of privileged familiarity in minimizing antipathies among the Yao of Nyasaland is pointed out by Mitchell: “Thus the joking between cross-cousins in the village context is a means whereby the hostility between the component groups is dissipated and harmony within the village maintained” (1955:203). *Utani* among the Luguru supports the hypotheses of Mitchell and Radcliffe-Brown, and that of the

latter in particular is supported by the Luguru case, for it recognizes that permitted disrespect may occur between clans and tribes as well as cross-cousins or affines.

The Luguru are a Bantu tribe numbering approximately 200,000 living in the Uluguru Mountains and adjacent plains in East-central Tanganyika. They follow the hoe-type of agriculture, most of them living barely above the subsistence level. While the population is fairly dense in some areas, there are few villages, as the people tend to live in dispersed hamlets consisting of a few huts of the cone-cylinder type of construction.

The key to the social structure is the matrilineal clan, and "clan" is used here to describe an exogamous local grouping, members of which own land in common and manifest a high degree of collective responsibility.³ Clan members believe they are related by descent from sisters who were among the first migrants of the clan to the Uluguru area. Each clan is headed by a senior elder who should belong to the particular lineage within the clan known in Luguru as *tombo dukuru*, or the "big breast." This segment of the clan is said to be descended from the eldest sister of the original migrants. The senior elder is assisted by a council of elders, some of whom control the affairs of their particular lineage within the clan.

Succession and inheritance ideally goes to the sister's son, and the avunculate obtains among the Luguru. While there is a tendency today to place an increasing emphasis on patrilineal descent and control, in former times under the avunculate the authority of a Luguru over his sister's children existed to a degree where he could dispose of them as slaves without the consent of the father. Residence is traditionally matrilocal and accompanied by mother-in-law avoidance. There are no traditional chiefs in the usual sense of the term, and no political integration beyond the clan was recognized prior to domination of the area by the Arabs and Europeans.

Every Luguru clan claims to have a utani relationship, involving joking and obligations, with one or more clans in their vicinity. While utani is a Swahili term rather than Luguru,⁴ it is being used here instead of the Luguru equivalent, *ugongo*, as this is the practice followed by the Luguru themselves. Actually, the term utani is not commonly used, but rather the plural and singular, *watani* and *mtani*. According to the Luguru, the utani relationship between clans developed as a result of warfare during the initial occupancy of Uluguru. An immigrant group would defeat, or be defeated by, a group already residing there, but the victors would permit the losers to remain and become *watani*. A less violent origin was reported for cases where immigrants would be given land to cultivate without fighting, and it was also stated that considerable intermarriage between two clans over a long period could result in their becoming *watani*.

JOKING AND PRIVILEGED FAMILIARITY

The greatest degree of joking is carried on between *watani* of the same generation, and cross-sexual joking is common, with obscene and suggestive

language and horseplay. What might otherwise be regarded as common assault becomes good clean fun between watani. For example, a man may jokingly grab a woman's cloth and attempt to disrobe her, and a good-natured tug-of-war or wrestling may result. A woman may deride a mtani about his lack of sexual prowess, and imply that he is sterile or impotent. He may respond with an invitation to accompany him in order to demonstrate his virility. The fact that a man is married does not prohibit him from indulging in a jesting conversation with sexual overtones, particularly with unmarried watani. However, it is considered bad form for a man to make suggestive or obscene remarks to a married mtani of the opposite sex unless her husband is present.

In an early article, Eggan suggested in a preliminary interpretation that avoidance and joking were alternative solutions for resolving what could potentially be serious conflicts between kinsmen. Avoidance and respect were likely to occur between different generations, with joking and license permitted between members of the same generation where a conflict situation is inevitable. He suggested that because of the potential for conflict, jokes, satire, and sexual play could be expected to be greatest between siblings-in-law (Eggan 1937:75ff).

The Luguru case does not support this interpretation in all respects. While a Luguru should show deference toward an elder, joking is permitted between all generations of watani, and the only avoidance observed is toward the mother-in-law. Admittedly, the potential for conflict is greatest between brothers-in-law, for with the avunculate, they both have a degree of control over the individual who is sister and wife. While the father must provide for and rear his children, the ultimate authority in the past has been the mother's brother. In spite of this, the Luguru do not single out in-laws as special targets for the more extreme forms of joking as suggested by Eggan, as in-laws need not be watani. If the greatest amount of joking does occur between watani who are affines, it is because they have more contact than others, and it does not differ in kind or in intensity from joking between watani who are not in-laws. Indeed, while mild joking may occur between siblings-in-law who are not watani, it is more of the type permitted among friends, and the extreme forms observed by watani would be considered bad taste.

With the pattern of matrilineal residence, the joking permitted between watani is functional in reducing friction in the compound or hamlet. The Luguru are emphatic in regard to the desirability of marriage with a mtani and it is definitely a preferential form of marriage. For one thing, a man is likely to be marrying into the clan of his father or grandfather, but, in any case, he will have been joking with his wife's clan for years. The only individual he should avoid is his mother-in-law, a rather difficult task when he lives virtually next door to her. In practice, mother-in-law avoidance exists more in theory than in fact; actually, mother-in-law and son-in-law visit and talk, although he always treats her with respect and no joking is permitted between them.

The position of the Luguru man in the hamlet is somewhat that of an

outsider, and he must compete, to a degree, with his wife's kin for control of his children. If his in-laws are also his watani, his position is somewhat easier, for a relationship exists that takes no offence at criticism, insult, or disrespect. This tends to dissipate hostility and maintain harmony, for, as the Luguru frequently say: "If you marry a mtani you do not have trouble."

A high degree of familiarity is permitted between alternate generations, and it is permissible for a youth to deride a mtani elder if at some time during the exchange he shows the proper respect. For example, a elder named Mbewa ("rat" in Luguru) approached the house of a young mtani and the latter started calling to those around to "kill the rat, kill the rat." The elder did not take offence, but, playing the game, threatened to kill the young man and chased him away with his walking staff. The young man returned shortly and greeted the elder in a respectful manner. It is also regarded as amusing to erroneously inform a mtani elder that someone has died and that his presence is required at a burial, or to tell someone at work on their farm they are needed at home. As farms may be two or three hours walking distance through the mountains, this can be something less than a laughing matter to the victim.

One type of bantering and joking that is not limited to watani is that between grandparents and grandchildren. The kinship terminology permits alternating generations to refer to each other as "brother" or "sister," and a young man may tease his grandfather about marrying his wife. The identification of alternate generations with each other is rather strong, and grandparents tend to take the part of the children against parents. When a parent would slap or strike a child, the grandparent might say "Why do you beat me?"

The Luguru case deviates from the common pattern of joking relationships in that reciprocal or symmetrical joking is permitted between contiguous generations of watani. It is not uncommon in the literature to find examples where it is permissible for a man to appropriate the property of a particular individual, such as a mother's brother. Indeed, a Luguru may walk off with the belongings of his maternal uncle without permission. If a youth needed a goat for a marriage payment, he could take one from his mother's brother, and the latter could not object. However, this is not part of the utani relationship, as the two are from the same clan. While joking is permitted between watani of first ascending or descending generations, it tends to be qualitatively different from that between watani of the same generation. It does not often involve sexual matters or obscenity (though it may), and is more likely to be of the erroneous message type listed above, taking property for ransom (see below), or joking at funerals.

Regarding the latter, considerable horseplay by the watani clan or clans of the deceased is permitted and expected at a burial. Attendance of some watani is required, and as a burial is a sad and serious affair, they attempt to introduce a bit of levity into the otherwise sorrowful occasion. To the crying woman they may say "Keep quiet, or we will come back tomorrow," thus threatening to delay the burial. They have been known to pour a pot of water

over a wailing woman under these circumstances. Or again, a mtani might say to the clan of the deceased: "You are crying too much. Give me one woman to take to my house so that I can give you a child to resemble the person who is dead." A mtani may lie down in the grave and pretend to sleep or demand a small sum of money to get out of the grave so the burial can continue. Preparation of the grave is the privilege of the watani, and they have been known to beat a member of the clan of the deceased who got into the grave. However, this was done in a jocular manner and without harm to the victim.

It is also permissible to appropriate the possessions of watani, but rather definite rules govern this type of acquisition. For one thing, it should be done openly and in the presence of the owner or his family. Confiscation is most likely to occur at a funeral when watani of the deceased may walk off with a goat, fowl, yams, or even such items as a hoe or panga. If a mtani saw three hoes by a house, he might say "You have too many hoes" and take one. Again, this is always done in a joking manner; the owner may not seriously object, and it is part of the expected routine or ritual at a burial. At time of death in the clan some Luguru have been known to move their livestock to another hamlet and hide items that might catch the eye of the acquisitive mtani.

Watani are also permitted to appropriate meat or produce being carried uncovered, and leaves or a branch should be placed over a headload of vegetables. An elder should never carry a load on his head, covered or not, for if he meets a mtani he risks confiscation; thus a youngster should accompany him if there is a load to carry. Also eligible for appropriation by watani is clothing with a ragged hem or ragged edge exposed, as is clothing turned inside out when it is placed out on the ground, a bush, or roof of a hut to dry. The right to confiscate such garments is said to be associated with, or derive from, the function and role of watani at the time of burial, which will be discussed below. A cheap grade of cotton cloth, known locally as *Amerikani*, is used to make this shroud or *sanda*, which is a crudely and hurriedly constructed sack. Watani may take anything carried in a bag resembling a sanda, or clothing that is unhemmed or has rough edges exposed. Garments laid out on the ground or on a bush are said to resemble a corpse, thus becoming fair game for watani.

In cases where a mtani sequesters produce or belongings, he should spit on them first, which indicates he is taking them because they are improperly carried, worn, or displayed. An interesting aspect of acculturation has occurred regarding the right of watani to take clothing placed out to dry. If it is hung on a clothesline, a trait borrowed from the European, it should not be taken even though it is turned inside-out.

However, property seized under these conditions is rarely retained permanently. While it would be legally permissible to do so, it is expected that it will be returned to the original owner after payment of a small sum, usually a fraction of a shilling, as ransom.

While most property is taken as a form of joking, a Luguru may go to a mtani and request food because of a special need such as a required ceremony. He may ask for a goat or grain, and discussion will ensue as to whether or not

he can pay for it, but he should not be refused. While he may agree to pay later, in all probability he will not compensate the owner. This is not cause for serious concern, as the procedure will be reversed at some future date. Luguru informants could not recall a case where a man had used his privilege as a *mtani* to acquire wealth he did not need or take advantage of the situation. It would definitely be considered anti-social behavior, and reciprocal action by *watani* would soon discourage such an unseemly practice.

SEXUAL LICENSE

There is general agreement among the Luguru that in former times a male, married or single, was permitted to have sex relations with his unmarried *watani*. While the practice is frowned on today in some circles, it is admitted that according to customary law a charge of adultery could never be validated in such a case.

The greatest amount of sexual license is permitted between unmarried cross-cousins, and an affair between these two is rarely condemned except by acculturated Christians. Cross-cousins are always considered *watani* and may be referred to as such whether or not their clans observe the *utani* relationship. When a young man was visiting his uncle no one questioned the propriety of his being left alone with a female cross-cousin while the adults went to the field. Thus sexual play often began at an early age and could result in sex relations prior to puberty. Cross-cousins may refer to each other as husband and wife, as this is the most desirable form of preferential marriage; and if a girl had sex relations with her "husband" it was not cause for serious concern. A Luguru may tell his nephew at night to "go call your wife," thus giving his sanction to premarital sex relations between his heir and his daughter. In short, little value is placed on virginity at time of marriage except by the educated Christian community.

A married or older man is more likely to seek out a widow or divorcee for extra-marital sex. For a husband this is most likely to occur while his wife is nursing a child,⁵ for the Luguru follow the common African pattern of females abstaining from sex relations for approximately 18 months following the birth of a child if the child lives. One factor that favors an affair with a *mtani* is that a charge of adultery would not be brought against the man by the relatives of the woman. Moreover, his wife is less likely to create trouble if he seeks the company of a *mtani*.

The joking between *watani* that permits highly suggestive or obscene comments thus may be utilized to ascertain the availability of a *mtani* as a sexual partner. While the fiction exists that a male should be the aggressor in sexual matters, under these circumstances it is possible for the female to initiate a verbal exchange that may lead to a proposition.⁶ It is expected that a young man will give a gift of a small amount of money or trinkets to a girl with whom he is having an affair, and an adult male who regularly visited a divorced or widowed woman is expected to be generous and contribute to her support, either in produce, cloth, or money. Such a woman would be referred

to as *hawala*, which the Luguru use to mean paramour or concubine, rather than *malaya* or prostitute. The latter term is used today in reference to women the Luguru claim come predominantly from other tribes, particularly the Haya, who make their living entirely in this manner. The joking aspect of utani entered into a situation in former times where a man would permanently cohabit with a mtani. It was reported that he could pay the bridewealth with a handful of grass, but when he left he should leave her a house.

Lest this account of what is permitted by custom distort the picture it should be noted that: (a) pre-marital and extra-marital sex relations are by no means limited to watani; (b) while affairs between watani are not condemned by the majority, neither are they encouraged, for it is rather a case of "since one must, it is better to seek out a mtani;" and (c) while it was conceded that most widowed or divorced women had at least an occasional affair, such behavior was considered unbecoming in married women. Moreover, pre-marital promiscuity was not as prevalent as might be assumed from the comments above about cross-cousins. Pre-marital sex relations were condemned unless the participants were cross-cousins or at least watani. Among other things the puberty rites for girls remove them from circulation for a considerable period of time following menarche. At this time they are isolated in a darkened room for from one to two years, emerging only to go to the latrine. During this period they receive instructions from designated female kin about sex and marriage, communicate only with women, move but little, and are fattened up for their debut. Traditionally, the marriage arrangements should be settled before their "coming out" party, an elaborate affair involving a day or two of dancing and beer-drinking, and the wedding should occur at the time they are returned to society, or shortly thereafter. While it is difficult to document, it appears that premarital sexual relationships and pregnancy are increasing because of the departure from this traditional practice of marriage shortly after the period of isolation. Length of confinement is being shortened, or in the case of some schoolgirls, eliminated entirely. Also, young men have difficulty acquiring the inflated bridewealth. Thus the period between the coming-out ceremony and marriage is considerably lengthened, thus increasing the opportunity for pre-marital sexual activity for many girls.

SOCIAL OBLIGATIONS

In one respect, utani may be defined as a jural relationship, for it must be viewed in terms of duties and obligations as well as rights and privileges. The obligatory aspect may be noted primarily at times of crises, such as birth, death, and disputes. Many examples could be cited, but the most common is the required presence of watani at burials. When someone dies, the neighbors and relatives may be notified by calling the message from house to house and farm to farm across the mountain, but the elders of the watani clan or clans of the deceased should be informed by messenger with a small gift of money. The function of the watani, in addition to the joking noted above, is assisting the clan in preparation of the body and interment. This includes washing the

corpse, making the shroud, digging the grave, carrying the body to the grave, and burial. The watani clan would be offended if they were not notified, for in addition to the slight, it would deprive them of their right to get even regarding confiscation of food. A recent development sometimes observed involves a payment of cash for sewing the shroud or washing the body, which varies from four to eighteen shillings, a stipened that a mtani is reluctant to pass up.

Watani also participate in ceremonies (*tambiko*) at the grave of the deceased, one held a month or two after burial and another several months later. A mtani will carry the beer used to pour a libation to the deceased and the ancestors, and watani also have the duty of clearing the grave of weeds and grass. During the prayers to the clan ancestors the watani may rebuke or coerce the dead, saying "You who have died, do not come back and cause trouble for the living," or they may admonish the elders to carry out the ceremony in the prescribed manner so as not to offend the ancestors. Joking may enter in here again, for when the names of ancestors are mentioned that a mtani does not recall, he may enquire "Who are they?" If the clan members are having difficulty remembering the names of ancestors to mention, a mtani may say: "What is the matter with you, do you not know the names of your ancestors?"

One finds watani constantly cropping up as arbitrators of a dispute or officiants at some ceremony. For example, in the ritual where blood-brotherhood is established between two friends, a mtani of each has a role, as do watani in the propitiation of the ancestral spirits when a case of incest has been exposed involving members of the same clan. When the estate of a man is settled, they oversee the distribution and adjudicate any dispute that may arise.

Another traditional practice where watani played a role was in cases of infanticide, where "unlucky" or "dangerous" children, known as *kigego*, were put to death. Examples of *kigego* would be one of twins, albinos, extreme anomalies evident at birth, or a breech presentation. The job of dispatching these neonates fell to one of the female watani present at the birth, usually a sister or mother of the husband. While infanticide is still admitted to occur today, particularly in the case of extreme anomalies, it is declining, and it is not uncommon to see twins. In one area there was a practice of giving some *kigego*, such as a child that cut the upper teeth first, to the wantani clan for adoption.

Duties that were not considered appropriate for the clan to perform, such as burial of someone who had died from leprosy or smallpox and the burning of his hut, were allocated to watani. Another duty was the removal of the fetus when a woman died with the child *in utero*. Senicide, or at least "expediting" the demise of individuals who were completely incontinent, in great pain, or insane to a degree where they constituted a menace, was reported as "done in the past." Although this could be achieved by sheer neglect, where it required overt action, such as poison or strangulation, it should involve the watani. While infanticide was readily admitted and discussed, for obvious

reasons⁷ it was more difficult to elicit information on senicide and what the Luguru regarded as mercy killing. While there was variation between districts as to duties and obligations of watani, one pattern did emerge—things that would be dangerous or distasteful to the clan could be carried out with impunity by watani without fear of retribution by the supernatural.

EXTENT OF UTANI IN TANGANYIKA

While data are lacking on many of the tribes, intratribal utani is present in varying degrees in the eastern part of Tanganyika from Mozambique to the Kenya border around Tanga. Informants from tribes surrounding the Luguru, namely the Kami, Kutu, Nguru and Kwere all stated they had utani relationships between clans. These tribes are also culturally and linguistically very similar to the Luguru. Brief publications on utani in Tanganyika (Scrivenor 1937:72; Moreau 1941:5) also list the Ngoni, Zaramo, Zigua, Digo, Sambaa, Bondei, Makua and Yao as having some form of utani relationship between clans or lineages. It may be noted that with the exception of the Ngoni these groups are all matrilineal, or tribes who have changed from a matrilineal to patrilineal type of kinship structure (Murdock 1959:310, 362). It is among these tribes that observance and practice of utani appears to have been retained to the highest degree.

The available material on intratribal utani is somewhat meager, but in the notes published by Scrivenor (1937), Moreau (1941) and Spies (1943) the following traits seem to obtain between members of watani clans of most tribes, although one cannot assume them to be present in all cases:

1. Joking, horseplay, jeering and obscene comments, irrespective of age or sex.
2. An obligation to function at funerals in preparation of the corpse for burial, digging the grave and providing the shroud.
3. The right to request or take food.
4. Assisting the watani clan in settling estates and adjudicating disputes. Serving as officiants at ceremonies is also noted.

Moreau (1941:8) records a system of forfeits similar to that recorded here for the Luguru, although he does not indicate the tribe or tribes. This includes the right of a mtani to confiscate meat carried improperly and clothes incorrectly worn or placed out to dry. He also makes the association between these clothes and a corpse as the reason for the forfeiture as well as noting the role of watani in disposing of lepers and "unlucky" children.

INTERTRIBAL UTANI

Some aspects of the utani relationship recorded here as occurring between clans are also observed between tribal groups by many of the Tanganyika tribes. With the exception of the Sambaa and Bondei, all of the tribes listed above as observing intratribal utani also consider themselves to be watani with one or more tribes. According to Moreau (1941), the list of tribes that

observe external utani should include Ngindo, Kinga, Gogo, Ha, Sumbwa, Tusi, and Nyakyusa, while Spies (1943) adds the Hehe and Sukuma. This list is not suggested as complete, as material is not available as yet to treat utani on a country-wide basis. However, if the tribes mentioned are located on the map it can be noted that there is a spread over much of Tanganyika. Also, if one assumes that the tribes that are listed consider one or more of the contiguous tribes who do not appear on the list as their watani, it seems likely that most of the Tanganyika Bantu tribes observe some form of internal or external utani relationship. Moreover, it does not follow that those listed as recognizing only external watani do not have some form of joking relationship within the tribe—it is just that more data are needed.

Intertribal utani, according to Luguru informants, resulted from two tribes having fought each other. This is supported by Moreau, who adds that two tribes had to fight each other “honorably.” Thus the Ngoni do not consider themselves watani of the Pogoro, as the latter, though defeated by the Ngoni, “fought dirty,” relying on ambush and poisoned arrows. He also records two tribes that could not be watani because they had never made war on each other (Moreau 1941:3). However, the Luguru also claimed the Nyamwezi were their watani because they always traded with them. The Nyamwezi, located around Tabora to the west of the Luguru, frequently made trips to the coast as traders and in the company of slave caravans. They traversed the edge of Luguru country on this route, and usually obtained supplies from them. It may have been that the Nyamwezi also defeated the Luguru at some time, for the latter were not particularly known as a warlike or aggressive people. Spies (1943:49) states that intertribal utani could result from a “good Samaritan act,” such as nursing an ill man back to health, paying a debt for someone from another tribe, or giving an honorable burial to an enemy killed in battle.

While it is possible that a good deed may result in a utani relationship between clans, or between those members of two tribes who are involved and live close to each other, it seems doubtful if such an act would be binding on the whole tribe. It must be recognized that there is not always agreement as to which tribes are watani of a given tribe. For example, the Luguru were consistent in claiming the Nyamwezi as watani; but while the Ngoni, Hehe, and Zigua were frequently mentioned, they were not always recognized as watani by Luguru informants. There appear to be two primary reasons for these variations, apart from the fact that an ethnographer rarely if ever encounters complete accord. One is that in case of war or a raid, the whole tribe would not be involved; thus different parts of the same tribe could develop their own external watani. Secondly, the concept of the “tribe” is fairly recent for many of the Tanganyika groupings, particularly the matrilineal tribes, who, prior to Arab and European domination, did not recognize any political authority higher than the clan or local level. The Luguru, for example, did not think of themselves as a “tribe” until after British control and the election of a sultan for the Uluguru area. Prior to this, they thought primarily in terms

of clan affiliation, and a few will still, when asked the name of their tribe, give their clan name. Consequently, when a Luguru from the north of the Uluguru Mountains says the Luguru are watani of the Zigua, it need not be expected that the same reply would be forthcoming from an informant raised on the other side of the mountain.

Material available on intertribal utani indicates that the behavior permitted members of watani tribes is somewhat limited compared with that outlined for the Luguru between clans. The following seems to obtain in most cases:

1. Jesting, joking and derisive or sometimes obscene comments, irrespective of age or sex.
2. If someone dies away from their tribal area, members of a watani tribe should aid with the burial.
3. Joking at funerals is permitted, as is confiscation or forfeiture of food and property under certain conditions, usually for ransom.

Luguru informants believed that joking with watani from another tribe should be somewhat more restrained than on an intratribal basis, and that sexual license would not be extended to include external watani. Luguru men felt free to joke with both sexes from a watani tribe, and some gave accounts of jokes played on them. For example, one elder said his suitcase had been confiscated by some Nyamwezi men in a railroad station in the Sagara tribal area, and he had to buy it back for half a shilling.

It may be noted that the utani relationship is limited to the Bantu-speaking tribes of Tanganyika, that none of Nilo-Hamitic, or what Murdock has termed "Cushitized Nilotes" (1959:328), such as the Masai or Tatog, are reported as being the watani of any tribe. While the Masai have been reported as having formed spurious blood-brotherhood relationships with Bantu tribes, deception was the intent, for they have no blood-brotherhood of their own. It seems unlikely that utani relationships would appeal to the Masai, as they would not condescend to recognize the Bantu as worthy enemies.

It appears plausible that the intratribal preceded intertribal utani in time, and that the latter is a projection of the former. Among the Luguru the system appears too deeply ingrained in the indigenous culture to have been adopted after contact with the raiding Ngoni and others in the 19th century. Moreau (1941:5) is also of the opinion that internal utani preceded external relationships on a tribal basis. It does not follow, however, that both intratribal and intertribal utani could not have diffused from other tribes, for this seems very likely to have occurred in the case of some tribes. The Yao of Tanganyika observe both, but Mitchell (1956:197) reports only a joking relationship between cross-cousins for the Nyasaland Yao. A similar situation is reported for the Tanganyika Ngoni as for the Tanganyika Yao, but nothing comparable to utani is reported for the Ngoni of Nyasaland or Northern Rhodesia, or for the Zulu from whom the Ngoni claim descent.

Given this setting, it is perhaps unrealistic to refer to "intertribal" utani, for, as indicated, it is apparently an extension of intratribal utani over a wider area. However, it is convenient to use "intertribal" in reference to these relationships because of factors which have increased the number of people who recognize external watani. The first of these is the introduction of the concept of "tribe" by the European. Secondly, over a period of time the acceptance of another tribe as watani has diffused over a wider area. Thirdly, improved communications and migration have increased intertribal contact, and along with this the opportunity for and desirability of utani relationships on a broader basis.

Intertribal utani serves much the same function as that described for intratribal utani. When one tribe had been defeated, a joking relationship, plus mutual obligations, arises to replace a potential master-slave situation. In contemporary Tanganyika, a changing society, intertribal utani still retains many of its traditional functions. With increasing migration, people from several tribes are found together in the towns and on sisal plantations or government projects. Privileged familiarity helps minimize tribal antipathies, as joking and jeering are not necessarily considered offensive. Also, watani from another tribe are present to fill certain needs if one's own kinsmen are not available.

SUMMARY

Among the Luguru the utani relationship is a jural one that may be defined in terms of rights, privileges and obligations. It permits privileged familiarity between watani clans regardless of age or sex. There is an obligation to assist watani in times of crises, participate in their ceremonies, and serve as mediator in disputes. Utani exists on an intertribal as well as intratribal level, and serves much the same function of dissipating hostility and maintaining harmony between groups.

The Luguru case supports the hypothesis of Radcliffe-Brown that joking is a manner of organizing a stable system of social behavior in which conjunctive and disjunctive components are maintained and combined. Given a pattern of matrilineal residence, when a man marries a mtani he is not a complete stranger in the compound of his wife. He has probably married into the clan of his father or grandfather, and has been joking with the kinsmen of his wife for years. The symmetrical pattern of permitted disrespect ameliorates his position as an outsider. The extension of joking into a degree of sexual license under certain conditions permits the male at least a semi-sanctioned form of extra-marital sex when a wife is not available, a factor some men consider important when they live surrounded by the kinsmen of their spouse.

Following an initial dominant-subordinate relationship between clans, continued intermarriage has, over the years, blurred the dominance of one over the other. Hostility has been minimized or avoided by privileged familiarity, which, along with mutual obligations, aids in maintaining social conjunction.

NOTES

¹ A condensed version of this paper was read at the annual meeting of the American Anthropological Association at Chicago in 1962. The field research during 1959–60 was made possible by a Senior Post-doctoral Fellowship from the National Science Foundation.

² For example, see the table in Murdock (1949:277). While this table deals only with behavior permitted toward females, it may be noted that the extreme forms of joking and license discussed in this paper are atypical.

³ There are several clans bearing the same name throughout the Luguru area and contiguous tribes. resulting from fission of groups during and after migration to Uluguru. In their discussion of the Luguru, Young and Fosbrooke refer to all groups bearing the same name as a maximal lineage or clan, with a major lineage defining the largest corporate group with proprietary rights to a particular area of land (1960:45ff). It is the major lineage that is used here to mean "clan," as this is the largest group that observes collective responsibility, owns land in common, acknowledges the leadership of a senior elder and shares the bridewealth or divides funeral expenses.

While all clans bearing the same name believe themselves to be somehow related and would not intermarry, the utani relationship of one clan would not be binding on, or recognized by, other clans by the same name comprising what has been described as the maximal lineage. Each develops its own utani relationship with contiguous clans.

Young and Fosbrooke note the presence of utani among the Luguru, but state that all clans do not have such a relationship (1960:44). However, the writer did not encounter or hear about a clan that did not claim to be watani with some other clan, and Luguru informants could not imagine a clan not having watani.

⁴ If the usual Bantu prefixes of the area were used, the tribe or the plural would be *Walaguru*, singular *Mluguru*, the area they occupy *Uluguru*, and the languages *Kiluguru* or *Kiswahili*. Unless otherwise indicated, Swahili terminology is used in this paper.

⁵ It is believed that a Luguru husband should abstain from sex relations during the latter stages of pregnancy and first few months following birth, even with another wife, lest he bring harm or death to the child. Even after this the child may cry if the father visits another woman and then handles the child. To avoid the crying a man may use a special medicine on his hands or bring the child a gift such as a bracelet. Needless to say, a husband that refuses to tend his child, or a child that cries a great deal, can arouse the suspicion of a wife.

⁶ While joking in this paper is discussed primarily in terms of masculine behavior, the same privileges are extended to females. There is also a limitation that should be noted on the extent that a male may become involved with female watani. It is considered incest (*fuzimoto* in Luguru) to have sex relations with someone from your own clan, and while polygyny is permitted, one may not be married concurrently to two women from the same clan. This would also be classed as *fuzimoto* because "it would be mixing the blood." The same taboo applies to a lesser degree to sex relations with watani in that a man should not have sex relations with uterine sisters, or even offspring of the same father. It would not be condemned if he had sex relations with watani from the same clan if they belonged to different lineages or extended families.

⁷ In addition to a reluctance to discuss with a European something that was known to be against the law, senicide or mercy killing was apparently not common, and thus more difficult to analyze in terms of precedents. Unlike infanticide, where disposal of "unlucky" children had supernatural sanction, senicide or mercy killing did not. Another difficulty in eliciting information was that though the practice was regarded as necessary in some cases, it was viewed with repugnance by most Luguru, for it implied a negation of the tradition of high respect for the elders.

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